



CANDIDATE

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TEST

Ethics MT25 Collection

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This paper contains twenty questions.

Answer **THREE** questions.

The paper is split into two sections, section A and section B.

Candidates taking Philosophy paper 128, Practical Ethics, **must not** answer any question from Section B.

Candidates **not** taking 128 Practical Ethics may answer freely from both sections.

1 Question 1

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Q1 (a) Does moral realism predict that there should be more agreement about ethics than there is? What does your answer imply about the plausibility of moral realism?

Moral realism is the commitment to at least two things. First, moral statements are truth-apt i.e. capable of being true or false. Second, there are some non-trivially true moral statements. Enoch adds the third commitment to distinguish subjectivist moral realist theories from objective ones: we take normative truths to be mind and response independent. I will follow Enoch in including the third condition, otherwise we might say that a minimal moral realism, compatible with subjectivism, can explain away disagreement about ethics as due to the fact that different societies have different standards. Furthermore, notice that whether moral realism predicts that there should be more agreement about ethics than there is depends on whether we treat normative truths to be causally inert or not. We may pose the question as a dilemma against the realist's plausibility: the moral realist has two options. Either, they predict that there will be some agreement about ethics, which typically requires them to say that there should be more agreement about ethics than there is, or they predict that there will be no agreement about ethics, which gives rise to an implausible moral skepticism we wish to avoid. As such, I am going to argue that the dilemma is false and that realism is plausible. I am going to argue that moral realism does not predict that there will be so much agreement about ethics because of the kinds of cognitive shortcomings we face. However, moral realism is still plausible because we need not be committed to an implausible moral skepticism. My argument proceeds in two steps. First, I show that moral realism does not predict that there should be wide-ranging agreement about ethics, or at least more than there actually is, given the cognitive shortcomings of individuals, particularly due to evolutionary pressures. Second, I contend that my answer does not reduce the plausibility of moral realism, given that it can give an explanation for why we have some agreement, averting us from moral skepticism. Specifically, I contend that it is the fact that oppressed groups have a special moral sensitivity to tracking normative truths and that evolution has privileged democratic regimes that has allowed us to come to agreement on some moral claims. The advantage of this view is also that it explains why we might still see so much disagreement.

Why moral realism does not predict much agreement about ethics

Whether moral realism predicts that there would be much agreement about ethics depends in part on what we think moral properties are. If they are causally inert, then moral realism would be disposed to predicting that there would be quite little agreement over ethical questions. In contrast, if one were a naturalist realist, treating moral properties as reducible to natural properties such as pleasure, then one would suppose that we have observational faculties that can acquire ethical knowledge, hence implying wide-ranging disagreement. It is apparent however that to reduce moral properties into natural ones are incredibly difficult -- even if we disregard the force of the Open Question Argument of considering whether "Is the Natural Property X analytically equivalent to goodness" is an open question since the naturalist might point out how water and H₂O are analytically equivalent but something that we can only come to know a posteriori, Jackson points out the following: even if we take redness to fix the meaning of "a property of a reflective surface that gives rise to redness under ideal conditions" by observation, we still take redness to be equivalent to that property a priori. The naturalist still has to face head on the claim about which natural properties are analytically equivalent to goodness, a priori.

All this is to say that I am treating moral truths as causally inert. Then, the question arises whether the moral realist thinks that we have reliable truth-tracking sensitivities to discern the moral truth. This, however, is difficult to argue. One path the realist can take is a sort of rationalist argument: that through the capacities for practical reasoning we all share, we converge to the moral truth. But as Street points out, our reflective processes depend very much on our starting point -- in fact, we may diverge in different directions when undergoing reflection. Consider Tom, having a strong commitment that "we should give up rights to pursue the greater good" vs Max who has a strong commitment to deontological constraints of never violating any rights. Suppose they investigate the trolley problem of whether to redirect the trolley to kill 1 or to stay the course and kill five. It may very well be the case that Tom strengthens his consequentialist commitments and says we should redirect the trolley while Max stays the course. All this is to say that we should not expect such a capability to reflect independent of our evaluative starting points. Furthermore, our capacities for practical reasoning are subject to various defects such as self-interest -- as Enoch notes that moral disagreements tend to be aligned, rather than against, self-interest.

On the flip side, we may think that these evolutionary pressures that Street talks about can help us track normative truth. But according to Street, this is being committed to a sort of bad science. The moral realist's story would be something along the lines of "moral truths help us flourish" and so evolutionary pressures push us to believe in certain moral statements that are true. But according to Street, this is worse than a hypothesis that evolution pressures push us to believe in evolutionarily expedient actions, such as having children etc. I am inclined to side with Street on this account, since some moral truths such as "it is bad to kill the vulnerable" does not align with helping an individual flourish, at least in the natural world.

Furthermore, an additional reason why I think that moral realism does not predict more agreement than there actually is is because I think at least some moral disagreements are actually disagreements about non-moral features. For instance, a large part about the disagreement about abortion can be reduced to debates over the metaphysical status of a foetus. Of course not all moral debates are reducible in this way, but this shows that there is more agreement than there actually is.

So, if the moral realist takes moral truths to be causally inert, then the moral realist does not at all predict that there would be much agreement about ethics, much less more agreement than there would actually be.

Why we still have some agreement (and no skepticism)

One might naturally conclude from what I have said thus far that moral realism must predict that there should be little to no agreement about ethics (which trivially satisfies the statement that there is not more disagreement than we expect). But this doesn't seem to be true -- we do agree on many things, such as that it is wrong to kill people, it is wrong to be racist etc. Further, we want to treat these as truths! So my answer may still give rise to an implausibility about moral realism -- since moral realism does not predict much agreement, we are committed to an implausible skepticism that is not a live option.

What the moral realist must do now is to give a plausible story about why there is even any such agreement at all. Enoch suggests the following hypothesis: let us accept that Street's hypothesis is true i.e. that evolutionary pressures push us to act in evolutionarily beneficial ways and have beliefs that such acts are good. But consider that what is evolutionarily beneficial is systematically related to what is pro tanto morally good. So, evolutionary pressures push us to believe that acting in evolutionarily beneficial ways is good, which in turn are precisely some of the moral facts. Note that Enoch's claim is quite minimalist: he is not saying that what is evolutionarily good is all morally good nor is he saying that all that is morally good is evolutionarily beneficial. This allays objections that suggest his hypothesis that "survival is good" is too much of a coincidence.

Yet, I am not really convinced by Enoch's story. It seems to me that certain claims i.e. it is wrong to exploit the vulnerable when they are not part of community is evolutionarily not beneficial, but something that faces wide-ranging agreement.

I think a better, alternative story is available, once we open up to consider anthropological lines of evolution, that also suggest a minimal claim over why we have some agreement. My story hinges on two claims:

1. People of certain (oppressed groups) have reliable moral sensitivities in virtue of their epistemic position
2. Democratic regimes are more successful and people in democratic regimes outlast others who are in totalitarian regimes.

I am going to take claim (2) for granted, since it seems empirically true. My object of focus is on (1). Why might we take people of certain oppressed groups to have reliable normative truth-tracking sensibilities? Srinivasan gives us the following case of Nour: Nour is an Arab woman who is invited to her boss's house for dinner. The boss and his family were very welcoming and they laughed a lot during dinner. However, Nour could not shake off the feeling that the host was racist, despite having no ability to articulate why she feels that way.

Now, suppose that the host was in fact racist -- do we think that Nour was justified, i.e. had some truth tracking ability, in believing this? I would be inclined to think so. The reason for this, according to Srinivasan, is that Nour is situated, in virtue of her group membership, to pierce through cases of bad ideology. More specifically, I think what she means is that Nour needs to partake in two epistemic standpoints: one from within the political hegemony where she is a recipient of racism and from outside the political hegemony due to her position as an "outsider" or marginalised group. One reason why it is so challenging to find a kind of truth-tracking faculty is that we privilege a kind of internalism about justification -- when we ask, in Enoch's example, how John comes to know so much about the remote Nepalese village, we expect him to be articulate his reasons. Yet, in cases of normative truths, we are inclined to externalist kinds of justification, where people are endowed with such faculties in virtue of their social and thus epistemic position. For instance, we might say that women, as a class, have a distinct epistemic advantage in understanding normative notions about childrearing and bearing because of their closeness to the means of reproduction. As a consequence, because democratic regimes have survived, democratic contestation has allowed for the propagation of these moral beliefs to others who may be victims of "bad ideology" or mistaken normative attitudes.

There are three advantages behind this view I would like to point out. One, it explains many of the agreements we have in ethics about harm and discrimination -- it is wrong to exploit the vulnerable or wrong to be racist, that Enoch's hypothesis cannot really explain. Second, like Enoch, it is a minimalist claim -- it does not claim that all moral facts are just those that people from oppressed groups are privy to, just that only some are. And so it is compatible with a lot of disagreement. Lastly, I want to note that this account is congenial with disagreement in a different way -- notice that democratic contestation is not only still going on, but often faces a lot of friction. Disagreement then, under this account, is treated as the path to agreement and a natural part of achieving agreement. Moral realism, under this account, expects disagreement as part of achieving eventual agreement.

Conclusion

Moral Realism does not predict that there would be much agreement, or more agreement than there actually is. Some might think that this commits us to implausible skepticism, but I have shown that there is a plausible story that certain classes of people have an epistemic privilege in tracking the truth and so explains some of our agreement, while also explaining why we still have so much disagreement, because it is part of democratic contestation.

Words: 2066

Answered.

2 Question 2

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Q18. 'If animal suffering mattered in the way that animal rights theorists believe it does, then we would be obligated to alleviate wild animal suffering.' Discuss.

Animal rights theorists believe that animal suffering matters because it harms the animal. In other words, the animal has a kind of moral status that involves a strong reason against harm and a reason to aid. To do this, we usually isolate a certain feature of the animal that gives it this moral status, such as the fact that it has interests (like Korsgaard's theory). Given that both domesticated and wild animals have the same feature, then the reason we have to prevent animal suffering applies both to domesticated and wild animals. The question then is an attempted reductio argument against the animal rights theorist: because we are not obligated to alleviate wild animal suffering, the animal rights theorist is wrong in believing that animal suffering matters because it harms the animal in some way. We have two options: either (i) we say that there is a version of animal rights which precludes us from being obligated to alleviate wild animal suffering, or (ii) we bite the bullet that we are in fact obligated to alleviate wild animal suffering.

I am going to argue that we should bite the bullet that we are in fact obligated to alleviate wild animal suffering. Note that the kind of obligation generated by an animal rights theory tends to treat obligation as denoting a (non-decisive) pro-tanto reason that may be outweighed by other considerations. But in the absence of other countervailing considerations, we must alleviate their suffering. My argument proceeds in three steps. First, I consider a version of animal rights that is based on special relationships that may allow for the compatibility of a theory of animal rights with a lack of obligation to help wild animals because they are not part of our society. I then argue that this theory is implausible, at least because it entails that we have no reasons against harming these wild animals ourselves. Second, I suggest that any kind of animal rights theory that identifies a kind of property an animal has as endowing it with moral status must consistently apply to both wild and domesticated animals and thus give us a pro-tanto reason to alleviate wild animal suffering. Lastly, I examine two objections -- namely that non-human caused wild animal suffering never involves wrong-doing and that it involves preventing predation -- and argue that both objections fail.

A special relationships account of animal rights

The key to the incompatibility of having an account of animal rights and having no obligation to prevent wild animal suffering is that the reasons we have to prevent animal suffering must be shared by both wild and domesticated animals, since moral status is almost always identified with having some sort of natural property. One way to avoid this then is to not identify having moral status with some sort of natural (monadic) property, but instead with a relational property.

This is what Anderson's theory of special relationships attempts to do: she argues that why humans have rights in the first place is due to the kind of special relationship we have with one another as part of the same human community, which membership is automatically given to us in virtue of being born human. This cleanly avoids any sort of underinclusive objection. Some interpreters say that she conceives of reciprocity i.e. the ability to respond to the interests, commands and claims of others rather than reflective reasoning is a necessary condition for being part of the human community, but this does not seem to help her theory at all, since it precludes many kinds of humans with severe disabilities from having moral status. Instead, I think that she conceives of reciprocity as one way in which a nonhuman can gain membership in society -- this is why domesticated horses and apes can be incorporated into human society, since they are capable of a minimal notion of reciprocity i.e. making mutual accommodations

to one another. Notice then that if wild animals are defined as those which are precisely not part of human society, we have no obligations towards them to relieve their suffering. Our reasons are only to those (including animals) within our society. As Anderson writes: we have no obligations towards "vermin" such as rats which are "so hostile to our interests".

But I am not sure that Anderson's theory is so successful, for it would imply that we not only have no obligations to relieve their suffering, but that they have no rights against us in inflicting suffering. If we accept the full force of this special relationships theory, we might kill a wild animal to make clothing for a domesticated animal -- while some might agree, most animal rights theorists would recoil at this result. Furthermore, it is only wrong of us to cause needless suffering on animals part of our society, but for wild vermin such as rats, we can cause as much torment as we like. Anderson has no good reply to this.

Why we have a pro tanto reason to alleviate the suffering of wild animals

I claim that basically all other animal rights theories give rights to animals on the basis of some feature of their being that all animals share. The conclusion of this, then, is that reasons against harming or towards aiding animals must be shared across relevantly similar animals. What I mean by relevantly similar animals is that on a utilitarian account, the animal's capacity to feel pain will give us reasons of differing strength to help them, but not an animal's "wildness". To illustrate this point, let us begin with Regan's argument for animal rights, which he begins from an understanding of why humans have rights. For Regan, humans have rights because they have a certain intrinsic value -- namely, that they are a subject-of-a-life. What Regan means by this subjecthood is that humans have a biography -- a history of desires, hopes and beliefs that are all bounded by one entity. Likewise, animals of a an intermediate sophistication also have such a biography and thus subjecthood. If humans have rights in virtue of subjecthood, then animals have rights in virtue of subjecthood. Furthermore, whether an animal has subjecthood depends on facts about its species and not whether it is wild or not. Let us put concerns about Regan's account being under-inclusive against persons in a permanent coma aside, since my argument does not hinge on the animal rights theory being the "correct one" -- we might switch Regan's account with Korsgaard's argument that animals have rights because things can be good or bad for them and the conclusion would not change. What the argument shows is that if we have an obligation to relieve animal suffering, it does not just mean we should stop eating animals and stop testing products on animals but that we should also help animals who we have no awareness of. To formalise this argument, the animal rights theory grants an animal with a set of rights R on the basis of some property P. The animal rights theory, to escape the implication of helping wild animals, must say that property P is something possessed by domesticated animals but not wild animals. This is, *prima facie*, implausible.

An immediate reply would be something along the lines of the following case. Consider an animal right in front of you that is suffering and an animal in Africa that is suffering. Suppose you might teleport to Africa in an instant. Which animal would you help? Most would say that you should help the animal right in front of you. The analogy then is that wild animals are like animals far away from us. If we have a weaker reason to help wild animals than an animal right at your doorstep, there must be something morally relevant about the fact that they are "wild". Since accounts of animal rights cannot account for this, they are wrong.

I think there are two replies. First, the detractor would have to admit that there is still some reason to aid the animal in Africa, even if it is outweighed by the reason to aid the animal right in front of you. So, perhaps the animal rights accounts are deficient in not being able to explain this, but it shows that intuitively, we must capture that we have some obligation/reason to help animals far away. Second and more importantly, the morally relevant property is not the fact that they are "wild" but far-away. Jackson makes a similar argument in response to the demandingness objection for utilitarianism -- why we are permitted to care about our family and friends is because we have better knowledge of their situation and thus are in a better position to help them. Since we want to maximise expected value, people should prioritise helping their loved ones. Likewise, we are in a better position to help animals right in front of us, rather than wild, far-away ones. To make the case clearer that wildness plays no part in our

intuitions, suppose that there is domesticated dog (that is not your own) and a wild dog in front of you, both suffering. I do not think that you should have a greater reason to help the domesticated dog than the wild dog (except in the case where you make the owner happier).

Notice that the absurdity of the claim is not that great either: the kind of obligation we have in alleviating the suffering wild animals that animal rights theorists suggest is not decisive -- it can be outweighed by countervailing considerations, such as the suffering of another human. All it says is that in the absence of such considerations, we are in fact obligated to help relieve their suffering.

Taken together, animal right theories do imply that we should come to the aid of wild animals, because they identify the moral status of animals (which grants them rights) through something both wild and domesticated animals have.

Objections to the obligation of alleviating suffering of wild animals

I have argued that the (pro-tanto) obligation of alleviating suffering of wild animals is something that flows naturally from an animal rights theory. Now, I attempt to show that the claim is not so absurd by considering two separate objections.

The first objection is what we may call the "no wrong-doing" objection: it is clear that if humans are the ones that caused the suffering of animals, then we should intervene and relieve their suffering. This is because we have violated a sort of right they possess. But absenting the cases of such animals, which would leave most wild animals in the picture, there is no wrong that has been done, and so no right that has been violated. We therefore have no obligation to come to their aid. One immediate reply is that we may not construct an analogous example for humans -- if I see a human on a street suffering because he has cardiac arrest, I ought to come to his aid because he has a full moral status. The upshot of this is that moral status both gives a reason against harming and also a reason to come to one's aid (relieving suffering). But perhaps the detractor might point out that we also want to say that humans have stronger rights than animals, and so the fact that we may not say something alike for humans is not an objection. However, notice that this shows that if we see a random domesticated dog suffering, it is perfectly permissible for us to walk by without helping. The animal rights theorist, to explain this, must argue why the animal's moral status is sufficiently strong to gain a reason against harm but not a reason to aid. I doubt that there is a coherent argument for this, since most theories of animal rights ground their claims of animal rights on a sort of property that humans share (but animals may have to a lesser extent). If anything, the animal rights theory should only admit that animals have a weaker right against interference and reason for aiding, not that they only have one of them.

The second objection is that it implies we should prevent predation, which is absurd. One big part of this intuition that this is absurd is that it gives rise to a Malthusian dystopia and thus harms wild animals. Of course, if preventing their current suffering only brings more suffering, then we should not do it -- this is perfectly consistent with a reason to alleviate wild animals' suffering. But suppose that we may do so in a way that does not bring about this suffering, such as through sterilisation. It seems to me then that much of the absurdity dissipates. One might argue that there is a principle of non-intervention to be observed, but notice that the principle of non-intervention typically holds within communities, rather than across two communities. When we see a cultural outgrowth within a community, we ought not to interfere, but if we see a genocide happening in another country, the principle of non-intervention seems impermissible. On this count, we should prevent predation, conditional on not causing more suffering, and so the implication of preventing wild animal suffering is not at all absurd.

Conclusion

Plausible animal rights theories do imply that we have an (non-decisive) obligation to prevent the suffering of wild animals. We should not at all treat this as an unwelcomed consequence, for we have seen, we have no good reason for thinking that it is an absurd conclusion.

Answered.

3 Question 3

Please type your answer below

Write your answer in the box below. Changes are saved automatically.

Q12 'Just as resources have diminishing marginal utility, so utility has diminishing marginal moral importance.' (DEREK PARFIT) Does it?

To treat utility as having diminishing marginal importance is to endorse Parfit's theory of prioritarianism -- namely, that it is better to benefit those who are worse off than those who are better off. Note that, on this account, it is better to benefit those who are worse off not because they are relatively worse off but because of their absolute position on the utility scale. The point of this theory is that, at least according to Parfit, captures our intuitions over equality.

I am going to argue that utility does not have diminishing marginal moral importance and that the prioritarian view is wrong. Instead, majority of our intuitions over the objectionability of inequality is over status inequality. My argument proceeds in three steps. First, I motivate the prioritarian view through contrasting it with Telic Egalitarianism and Deontic Egalitarianism, which gives us reason to think that utility does have diminishing marginal moral importance. Second, I argue that Parfit underspecifies the kind of diminishing marginal moral importance utility has, but that regardless of how we work it out, prioritarianism has unacceptable conclusions. Lastly, I give a positive argument that prioritarianism should be rejected in favour of a relational conception of egalitarianism -- that inequality is wrong because people lose respect and effective access as participants of civil society.

Motivating Prioritarianism

Why might we think that utility has diminishing marginal moral importance? For Parfit, it seems to arise as a consequence of the unpalatability of both telic egalitarianism (it is in itself better in one way that people are less badly off than others) and deontic egalitarianism (inequality is wrong because it involves the wrong-doing of treating people unfairly i.e. on the basis of morally irrelevant characteristics) in explaining what is morally objectionable about equality. The Telic Egalitarian is vulnerable to what Parfit calls the "Levelling Down Objection" -- suppose that there is a natural disaster that wipes out all excess capital possessed by those better off. There is no improvement in the state of affairs of the worse off. The Telic Egalitarian must say that this state of affairs is in one way better even though no one is made better off. In contrast, the Prioritarian avoids this objection since the worse off receives no benefit, while the better off suffer -- hence the prioritarian thinks that the natural disaster is bad. The Deontic Egalitarian is vulnerable to the problem of natural inequalities. Suppose there is a case in which half the world is blind while the other half is sighted. Because the deontic egalitarian attaches the objectionable nature of inequality to an appeal over comparative justice i.e. being unfairly treated, and because there is no wrong-doing involved in natural inequalities, the deontic egalitarian would not think there is a reason to redistribute eyes. But I think this objection is too quick, for it is not as if the deontic egalitarian totally ignores natural inequalities -- instead, they take natural inequalities as morally arbitrary and hence wrong reasons to treat someone differently over. The deontic egalitarian says that we have no reason to distribute eyes, but we have a reason to make sure the blind has a fair start to life in society through ensuring that they are not disadvantaged in society i.e. through compensation. Parfit's objection, as it stands loses its force. However, there is a separate way in which the deontic egalitarian misses the mark -- when inequalities occur out of choice. Suppose that there is an extremely lazy man who grew up rich but gambles away all his money and becomes struck in poverty, unable to eat; in contrast, another woman works as hard as she can and becomes a billionaire. The deontic egalitarian cannot give a reason why we should aim for equality, or what is wrong about this case (other than the noncomparative fact that the man is starving). Like in the Telic case, the prioritarian avoids this because it is just better to benefit the poor man than taking away money from the billionaire.

In short, prioritarianism is motivated by its success in explaining cases of when inequality is bad and when inequality is not bad. One might point out that unlike the deontic or telic egalitarian, prioritarianism lacks a proper moral foundation and is an "ad hoc" form of utilitarianism. I am not sure how powerful an objection this is -- we might say its explanatory strength is evidence that this is why inequality is bad in certain cases and why it is permissible in others. Alternatively, and a better response I suggest, is that it seems compatible with a Rawlsian contractarian position. From the Original Position where individuals construct rules for institutions of society and yet no nothing about their particular social positions and fortunes, it might be argued that the prioritarian rule emerges instead of the difference principle. The prioritarian rule, at least when given lesser priority than Rawls' principle of liberty, seems as compatible as the difference principle. Waldron similarly points out that his own principle of a "social minimum" is compatible with Rawls' Original Position -- so it seems that it is not definitive that the difference principle emerges from the contracting position, and there is space to argue that the prioritarian the emerges.

Why Prioritarianism is wrong

I am going to claim that prioritarianism is deeply vague and underspecified. Prima facie, our imagined prioritarian rule is something like: there exists a multiplier $k(x)$ inversely related with your actual level of welfare x , that multiplies your actual level of welfare x when considering society's total welfare. Furthermore, we think that $k(x)$ constantly decreases as x increases. I think that this second claim is clearly implausible -- are we really to say that benefitting Stephen Schwarzman is better than benefitting Jeff Bezos, which is in turn better than benefitting Elon Musk? To put this more concretely, it would be better for me to give \$10 to Schwarzman than it would be to Musk. But I don't think that this is true at all, even if we consider the intuition that it is wrong to give \$10 to anyone of them, since the prioritarian must be committed that it is better for me to give Schwarzman the money than Musk. The upshot of this is that, it seems that, $k(x) = 1$ after a certain threshold. But how plausible is this? Suppose we set the threshold to having \$10 million dollars in assets. Then, it means that we weigh the interests or welfare of everyone below \$10 million dollars more than proportionately since $k(x) > 1$. But notice that this is true even if someone has 1 less cent than \$10 million dollars. To formalise this claim, the prioritarian seems to be committed to the following principle: for any value $c > 0$, the welfare $x - c$ is weighted more than the welfare of x . In other words, the prioritarian says that any infinitesimal difference in utility is a reason to weigh your utility, and therefore interests, less. Notice that this objection is true even if we do not endorse a threshold version of prioritarianism when $k(x) = 1$ after some level of x .

The reason why this flies in the face of common sense is because our moral outlook (and in particular utilitarianism) is undergirded by the idea of the equal moral significance of persons. It seems plausibly congenial with our idea of equal moral significance that we weigh someone with much less utility more, because the state of affairs that that person face is noticeably worse. However, at the margins of an infinitesimally small difference, this is not true -- there does not seem to be a relevant difference between someone with 1 million dollars or 999,999 dollars.

Of course, this objection also runs against the Telic (but not the Deontic Egalitarian) but it shows that prioritarianism and telic egalitarianism share a fault in their own understanding of egalitarianism.

Relational Egalitarianism

The upshot of the last analysis is that the extent of the inequality matters. We do not want to be committed to the claim that an infinitesimally small difference is in itself bad or that it is necessarily better to alleviate that difference. If we can do this, while avoiding the objections that prioritarianism does (and thus explaining when inequality is wrong adequately), then we should reject prioritarianism. One way, then, of interpreting this idea that the extent of the inequality matters is that inequality is that we are really concerned when people do not have enough. This idea of sufficientarianism is to suggest that the cases in which we care about

inequality just are cases in which persons are terribly impoverished, or do not have enough. I do not think this is very plausible, because the idea of "what is enough" seems to be absolute, and independent of how much others has. But consider the case in which I have enough to get by, but there is a trillionaire living in my community. There seems to be something wrong or bad about the fact that there is such a trillionaire living in my community. So even though I have enough (and if I am the worst off in the community), there still seems to be something wrong about the existence of someone so much more better off than I am.

I want to suggest that the sufficientarian idea of "what is enough" has promise, but we must extend the idea to be more relativistic. Whether we have enough depends, in part, on whether we have enough to pursue our own reasonable conception of the good life. This bears on whether we have a kind of equal access to civil society, or as Anderson puts it, a kind of status or relational equality with others. So, when I have just enough and someone else is a trillionaire, the reason why this is wrong is because my status is necessarily relegated to that of being lower than him, and because my access to society is simply so much worse than his. This clearly avoids the argument from marginal differences which the prioritarian is vulnerable to, since a mere difference of a cent does not undermine one's status or relation to another. In effect, we conceive of "what is enough" as dependent on how much others has -- inequality is bad when it undermines the status of individuals and their relation to one another, which tends to involve cases of substantial inequality.

Notice as well that this relational egalitarianism, motivated by status equality, implies that wrong-doing is sufficient, but not all there is, to imply that inequality is wrong since an unfair treatment of me based on arbitrary reasons is precisely to undermine my status.

I want to note two further advantages in favour of relational egalitarianism, to give us a decisive reason to reject prioritarianism. First, it may avoid the objection faced by the deontic egalitarian over inequalities generated by choice. It maintains that not all inequalities generated by choices are bad, but that we should come to the aid of those (i.e. through redistribution) who made imprudent choices when it undermines the kind of status that they have. This gives us a good explanation, I think, over when inequalities generated by choice are wrong, and when they are permissible. Second, it gives us cases in which the Levelling Down Objection loses its force. Suppose there is a society in which a natural disaster wipes out the extreme excesses of the upper class. If this rectifies the status inequality of the worst off, then we might not be so disinclined to admit that the state of affairs improved in one way. Indeed, the reason why we can admit that the state of affairs has improved in one way is precisely because that it actually has improved -- an improvement in material welfare is not the only way in which someone's position may be improved; the fact that I now can partake in society as equals is also a way in which my station can be improved. The prioritarian cannot account for such cases when Levelling Down leads to non-material improvements, since it is relegated to only considering material welfare.

It seems to me then, that the prioritarian claim is in fact false, since we have a much better explanation of when inequality is wrong, according to the relational egalitarian.

Conclusion

I have argued that utility does not have diminishing marginal moral importance i.e. the prioritarian view is false. This is primarily because it would have to be committed to a case of someone's utility being infinitesimally less than another as a reason to weigh his interests more, which flies in the face of our intuitions and commitment to the equal moral significance of persons. Furthermore, I have given a better account in explaining our egalitarian intuitions through relational egalitarianism. Taken together, we should reject Parfit's claim as false.

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Answered.